



aside the G50V looks good. Hinge build quality so-so. Open her up and the screen is matte. Thankfully the resolution is an ideal 1440 x 900 pixels; ideal for a 15.4-inch notebook. The screen bezel is a little too thick and spoils the look while adding bulk. The keypad is neat and similar in design to Dell laptops with slight impressions on the top of each key for your finger. The number keypad is a plus. The backlit, touch-based buttons shortcut keys work well and look nice. A blue monochrome LCD displays certain system parameters and some might find this intrusive – thankfully it can be disabled. The trackpad surface is good and has a nice blend of feedback and tracking. And best of all its pretty responsive, our only grouse is that it's small. Of course the fact that it's recessed into the body is good since your palm or wrist will not accidentally activate it while using the keypad. All in all, it's miles ahead of the MSI GX620X's trackpad. Viewing angles on the display are so-so although brightness levels are pretty good. One of the USB ports is placed on the rear – good for USB printers and such. The E-SATA and HDMI ports are located conveniently and on the side.

The GeForce 9700M GPU is reasonably powerful and will play most games other than the more demanding ones like Crysis and Clear Sky albeit

at lower levels of detail. The mighty Logitech MX518 mouse is bundled with this notebook, of course its got ASUS branding on it. You also get a funky bag, in fact the laptop ships inside the bag and not some ugly carton. ASUS is obviously selling this one marked to gamers on the basis of its exclusiveness, but at a price tag of Rs. 1,15,000 the G50V is a little to hard to swallow and its going to take more than some fancy lighting and packaging to make us even consider shelling out so much.

Alienware M17x Totally clichéd but 'here comes the game'

This is the first Alienware notebook we've laid our grubby paws on this year and quite frankly we're impressed. Forget about a weapon for gamers, the M17x is a weapon incognito – its amazingly sturdy construction and ponderous bulk means it can be used to bludgeon just about any living being to oblivion and that includes a woolly mammoth! And it's attractive looking too, with a black coloured, matte finish all over the body and the lid. The body is very thick; no wonder given it's innards. The front slopes forward giving it a very aggressive sports car bonnet like look and grilles embedded into the front light up with embedded red LEDs. The lid closes with a nice positive snap. The 17-inch



Alienware M17x

display is really clear and crisp with a high resolution of 1920 x 1200 pixels. Viewing angles are good. The integrated speaker is one of the best we've seen on a notebook – good bass, a great mid-range and extended highs. This notebook had the best speaker from this years bunch.

The *Alienware* branding is boldly illuminated in pink, however some of us found this too feminine a colour for an obviously masculine product. The keypad is well laid out and really good, suitable for a lot of office work (not that you would want to do that on this notebook anyway) and ergonomics is top class. The trackpad is a let down – it lags and tracking accuracy is rubbish – really a shame and the only blemish on a near perfect report card.

This freak has got premium innards to go with its menacing profile – a quad core processor – something unheard of for a notebook and not one, but two, GeForce GTX 260 GPUs in SLI. A massive 2 GB of GDDR3 video memory (1 GB per card)

should be sufficient for most games. The 220-odd frames per second in *Doom 3* and 45 frames per second in *Crysis* was enough to convince us that this notebook can indeed be used by a gamer. And guess what – this is Dells cheapest configuration for the Alienware M17x, which can be configured with dual GTX 280 GPUs – pretty mean. Sadly this won't stand up to a really fast desktop in terms of performance but then if you want the best, fastest notebook out there be prepared to shell out Rs. 1,39,000 for it or Rs. 2,25,000 for the highest configuration – either way you won't find as powerful a notebook. It wins our *Digit Best Performance* award for the best gaming notebook around and the most powerful configuration.

APPLE NOTEBOOKS: Hi-yo Silver...away!

Apples notebooks are called Macbooks for those who didn't know. Not only do these notebooks run Apples' own OS called "Leopard" or OS X but they're pretty different compared to other Windows-based notebooks. Whether this is good or bad depends on whether you're a fanboy or a hater. Needless to say our Windows-based benchmarks do not work with OS X, however the hardware used by these notebooks is the same.

GAMING: DESKTOPS OR NOTEBOOKS?

Have you always wondered just how good a gaming notebook is at gaming? We receive hundreds of mails a month from readers wanting to buy a notebook for gaming. We typically ask them their budgets and if that is anything under Rs. 75,000 (which it usually is) we suggest a desktop instead. If you're one of those readers, this is for you. It's no mystery that gaming notebooks are never going to be as powerful as desktop counterparts simply because its not possible to shrink powerful components to a notebook-

worthy size without reducing their performance. So a GeForce 9600GT graphics card will be will be more powerful than a GeForce 9600GT M (for mobility) notebook graphics solution. Just to see what happens we tested the Alienware M17x alongside a powerful PC.

The PC specs were as follows:

Intel Q9650 CPU, 2 x 2 GB 1066 MHz DDR2 RAM, ZOTAC GeForce GTX 285 GPU and 1 TB WD Black Edition HDD. Here are the scores:

	Alienware M17x	High-end PC
PC Mark05		
Overall	8589	9783
CPU Score	8059	9557
Memory Score	5496	6258
Graphics Score	14086	13539
HDD	5308	5618
3D Mark 2006 CPU Score	3722	4623
3D Mark 2006 Overall Score	13637	15627
Maxxon CineBench R10 (CPU Score)	9914	10967
DivX Encode 7.0 (.VOB to .Divx) *	42	38.5
File transfer Test (4 GB test file-sequential) (Sec)	23.94	34.68
File transfer Test (4 GB test file-assorted) (Sec)	20.96	25.13
Doom 3 (fps) (1024 x 768, Ultra Details)	220.4	260.4
Company Of Heroes (Tales Of Valor)	103.9	167.3
STALKER Clear Sky (1024 x 768, Max, DX10)	52.1	67.6
Crysis (1024 x 768, DX10, medium detail)	45	50
* Less is better		